



Plant focus: dahlias

Bold and beautiful, dahlias decorate the garden from summer to early fall with vividly colored and varied flowers.

COMPRISING TEN DIFFERENT FLOWER FORMS, and with plant sizes ranging from compact to towering giants, dahlias can be used in a wide variety of garden situations. Use ball, pompom, and rounded decorative dahlias to create spherical accents in a border of plant spires, such as mullein and salvias, and try spiky cactus forms to add drama and texture to a scheme. Single and collarette dahlias complement naturalistic designs, such as prairie-style borders, and many single varieties attract bees and other beneficial insects. Diminutive bedding dahlias are perfect for patio containers, while taller varieties suit large pots, but their bloom-laden stems may need staking. Dahlias are easy to grow from tubers or young plants bought in spring. Set them outside in a sunny position in free-draining soil after all risk of frost has passed. Also guard them against slugs, which can decimate plants. Bring tubers inside over winter or, in mild areas, cover them with a thick mulch.

USING DAHLIAS

Short-stemmed dahlias are perfect for patio planters and bedding schemes and give a long display if deadheaded regularly. Taller varieties are best suited to borders, where they can be given additional support. Dahlias with long stems are ideal to use as cut flowers and can be picked regularly from midsummer.

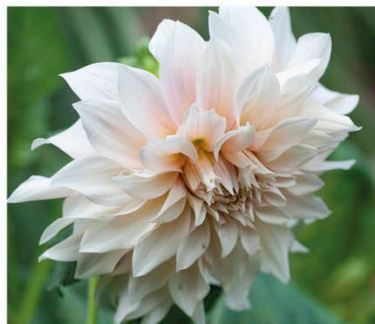


Dwarf dahlias that don't fit any of the eight main groups are often sold as bedding plants for pots and baskets. Overwinter the tubers or discard them at the end of the season.

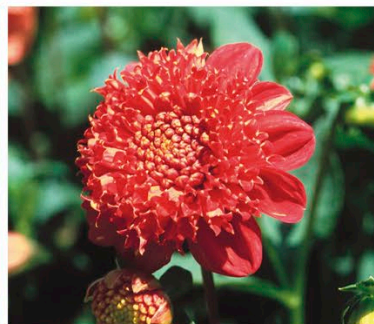
Dahlias such as 'Bishop of Llandaff' (*right*) and 'Yellow Hammer' have dark foliage, providing a dramatic contrast to brightly flowered plants.



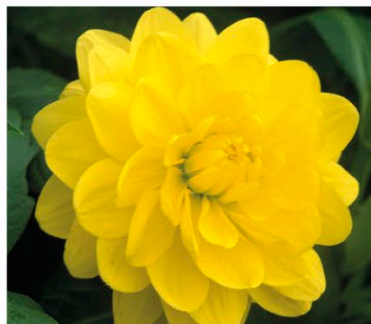
TYPES OF DAHLIA



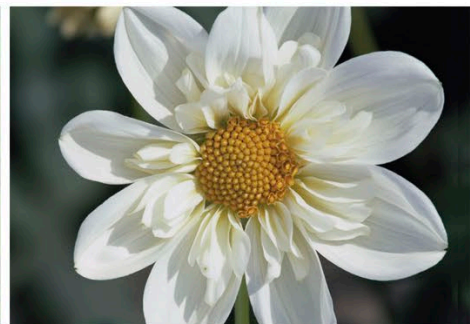
Decorative The fully double ruffled flowers are composed of broad petals that may have gently twisted or curved edges.



Anemone The fully double flowers comprise one or more rings of flattened petals overlaid with shorter tubular petals.



Water lily The fully double blooms are comprised of flat or slightly curved petals and resemble those of water lilies.



Collarette The flowers are formed of oval petals with an inner ruffled "collar" made up of smaller petals surrounding a central disk.